CHALLENGE 06 · TWELVE WEEKS

Half marathon training plan for beginners and advanced runners

Twelve weeks to 21.1 km: one plan for your first half marathon and one for a new personal best – with long runs, clear pace guidance, recovery weeks and tips on fuelling and recovery.

21.1 km with a plan

Twelve weeks with recovery and taper – for your first finish or your next personal best.

12 weeks · 2 levels

How a training week is structured

3–5 runs a week · Long run up to 120 min · 80% easy

Easy runs · the foundation	Most of your kilometres are run at a conversational pace. They build endurance and spare your tendons and joints.
One quality session per week	Faster sections, intervals or race-pace running make you quicker. Always with a 10–15 min warm-up and a 10 min cool-down.
The long run · once a week	It grows week by week and makes the distance familiar. Pace: easy, and slower than you think is fine.
Rest days and strength	At least one rest day after hard sessions. Two short strength sessions a week help prevent overload.

80 / 20 as a rule of thumb:
About 80% of your running time is easy and at most 20% fast or hard. Running every session fast often makes you tired rather than faster.

Your training plan

Both plans last twelve weeks, with recovery in weeks 4 and 8 and a lighter final phase before the race. Repeat a week if it feels too hard.

Beginner: your first half marathon

3 runs a week · Goal: finish

Week	Training	Done
Week 1 Long run: 60 min	**2× 30 min easy · long run 60 min** Getting used to the higher volume – everything at a conversational pace.	☐
Week 2 Long run: 65 min	**2× 30 min easy · long run 65 min** The long run grows in small steps.	☐
Week 3 Long run: 70 min	**35 min easy with 4× 1 min brisk · 30 min easy · long run 70 min** Your first brisk sections – jog easily for 2 min after each.	☐
Week 4 Long run: 60 min	**2× 30 min easy · long run 60 min** Recovery week: a little less, so your body can adapt.	☐
Week 5 Long run: 80 min	**35 min easy with 6× 1 min brisk · 35 min easy · long run 80 min** Take something to drink on the long run.	☐
Week 6 Long run: 85 min	**40 min easy with 3× 5 min brisk · 35 min easy · long run 85 min** The brisk sections get longer but stay controlled.	☐
Week 7 Long run: 95 min	**40 min easy with 3× 6 min brisk · 35 min easy · long run 95 min** On the long run, test the drink and snack you plan to use on race day.	☐
Week 8 Long run: 75 min	**2× 30 min easy · long run 75 min** Second recovery week: recharge for the final block.	☐
Week 9 Long run: 105 min	**40 min easy with 2× 10 min at half marathon pace · 35 min easy · long run 105 min** For the first time, sections at your planned race pace.	☐
Week 10 Long run: 115 min	**40 min easy with 2× 12 min at half marathon pace · 35 min easy · long run 115 min** The longest run of the plan – about 16 to 18 km.	☐
Week 11 Long run: 80 min	**35 min easy with 15 min at half marathon pace · 30 min easy · long run 80 min** Volume drops: now you build freshness for race day.	☐
Week 12 Goal: 21.1 km	**2× 25 min easy – then your half marathon** Two short runs, plenty of sleep and 21.1 km at a steady pace at the weekend. Walking through the aid stations is completely fine.	☐

Advanced: half marathon personal best

4–5 runs a week · Goal: new personal best

Every week: one quality session, one long run and easy runs. Warm-up and cool-down are not included in the figures.

Week	Training	Done
Week 1 Long run: 80 min	**3× 10 min at threshold, 2 min jog recovery** Plus 2–3 easy runs of 40–50 min.	☐
Week 2 Long run: 90 min	**6× 1 km at 10 km pace, 2 min jog recovery** Plus 2–3 easy runs of 40–50 min.	☐
Week 3 Long run: 95 min	**2× 15 min at threshold, 3 min jog recovery** Plus 2–3 easy runs of 40–50 min.	☐
Week 4 Long run: 75 min	**6× 2 min brisk, 2 min jog recovery** Recovery week: just 2 easy runs on top.	☐
Week 5 Long run: 100 min	**3× 12 min at threshold, 2 min jog recovery** Run the last 20 min of the long run at half marathon pace.	☐
Week 6 Long run: 105 min	**8× 1 km at 10 km pace, 90 s jog recovery** Plus 2–3 easy runs of 40–50 min.	☐
Week 7 Long run: 110 min	**2× 20 min at threshold, 3 min jog recovery** Within the long run, 3× 10 min at half marathon pace.	☐
Week 8 Long run: 80 min	**6× 3 min brisk, 2 min jog recovery** Second recovery week: just 2 easy runs on top.	☐
Week 9 Long run: 110 min	**3× 15 min at threshold, 3 min jog recovery** Run the last 30 min of the long run at half marathon pace.	☐
Week 10 Long run: 120 min	**4× 2 km at half marathon pace, 2 min jog recovery** The longest run of the plan, run easy. Test your fuelling.	☐
Week 11 Long run: 90 min	**2× 12 min at threshold, 3 min jog recovery** Taper begins: shorten easy runs; include 20 min at half marathon pace in the long run.	☐
Week 12 Goal: 21.1 km	**4× 1 km at half marathon pace – then your race** Short, easy runs and plenty of recovery. At the weekend, 21.1 km – keep the first half deliberately controlled.	☐

What the terms in the plan mean

You do not need a heart-rate watch – your own sense of effort is perfectly enough to start with.

01

Easy

You can talk in full sentences. This is the pace for most runs and for the long run.

02

Brisk

Noticeably faster; you can only speak in short sentences. For short sections of one to five minutes.

03

Threshold

Comfortably hard: you could hold this pace for about an hour but can only say a few words.

04

Race pace

The pace you are aiming for on race day – whether 5 km, 10 km or a half marathon. In training you only run it in sections.

Training with heart rate?

If you use a heart-rate watch: easy runs are usually in zone 2, threshold sections in zone 4. You can estimate your zones with the heart-rate zone calculator.

Heart Rate Zone Calculator

What matters most

01

Practise fuelling

On runs longer than 75 to 90 minutes, water and easily digestible carbohydrates can help. Test in training what your stomach tolerates.

02

Test shoes and clothing

Only race in shoes and clothing you have already worn on long training runs.

03

Keep the first half calm

The most common half marathon mistake is starting too fast. Run evenly and pick up the pace at the end.

Safety first

If you have been inactive for a long time, have a medical condition (for example of the heart or circulation) or take regular medication, get medical advice before you start. Stop immediately if you experience chest pain, unusual shortness of breath, dizziness or palpitations. Pain that gets worse while running or is still there the next morning is a reason to take a break – if it persists, have it checked. This challenge is not medical advice.

My notes